

The Art of Playful Teasing

In this lesson, we're exploring the art of playful teasing and clever comebacks, a staple in everyday British interactions. We'll look at how to recognise and participate in these exchanges without crossing the line into rudeness while enhancing your English fluency and social interactions. We'll break down real-life examples so you understand every witty remark. Let's get started!



What is playful teasing?

Imagine you and your friends decide to spend an evening doing karaoke. One of your friends, despite her enthusiasm, doesn't quite hit the right notes. After her performance, she asks, '**So, how was it?**' You respond with, '**Don't give up your day job!**' suggesting she's better off continuing with her current profession rather than starting a career as a singer.

This is an example of **playful teasing**. It's a way to add a bit of humour and irony into a potentially awkward situation without the intent to offend and we Brits happen to love it!



Important

Humour and teasing are **subjective**. Teasing crosses into bullying when you are purposefully trying to hurt someone's feelings and that's **never acceptable**.

Always consider the feelings of others and **err on the side of caution** if you're unsure how your words might be received. Remember, it's entirely possible for someone to laugh on the outside while feeling extremely uncomfortable on the inside.



CONVERSATION: PART 1

Now, here is the transcript of the conversation you heard in my video lesson. It's a conversation between two friends who decide to participate in a local pub quiz. After you read through the dialogue, I'll break down the examples of teasing and witty comebacks to help you understand the dynamics of such exchanges.

Alex: Oh, look! There's a pub quiz on tonight. Fancy joining?

Jamie: **You're having a laugh, aren't you?** I'm terrible at trivia!

Alex: **You and me both,** mate!

Jamie: Alright! I'm in for a few pints but this trivia business is all you.

Alex: No worries, I've got this! I crush it on Trivia Crack.

Jamie: I'll bet you do - **you and your trusty pal Google.**

Alex: I bet that sounded a lot funnier in your head.

Jamie: You know you love it!

Alex: Oh, for sure! It's what holds our friendship together: you joking and me pretending it's funny.

Jamie: Well, keep pretending. I don't think my ego could take it.



Language Explanation

You're having a laugh, aren't you?

This is a classic expression and one you need to have at the ready. When someone says something totally wild or unbelievable, and you assume they are joking, you can hit them with, **You're having a laugh, aren't you?**

It's like saying, '**Come on, you can't be serious!**'



You might also hear other common expressions with a similar meaning:

- **to take the mickey/mick (out of sb.)** - to tease or mock someone
- **to pull sb.'s leg** - to joke or tease in a friendly way
- **to have sb. on** - to joke with someone

You and me both

When Alex says, '**You and me both, mate,**' it's his quick, friendly way of letting Jamie know that neither of them is exactly a quiz master.

'**You and me both**' is a common phrase, meaning 'I feel the same way' or 'we're in the same situation'. Alex is basically saying, '**Don't worry about it, mate. We're going to be bad at this together.**'

It's a bit of **self-deprecating humour**, which is a way of making fun of yourself or downplaying your abilities for the sake of the joke. It's quite common in these kinds of back-and-forths with friends.

I'll bet you do.

When Jamie says, '**I'll bet you do - you and your trusty pal Google,**' she's using **sarcasm** to tease Alex about his confidence in winning the pub quiz. The sarcasm here implies that Jamie doesn't genuinely believe Alex is a trivia expert; instead, she humorously suggests that he is more of an expert Googler, meaning he can look up the answer very easily.

It's a playful way to call out Alex's sudden burst of confidence and adds another layer of fun to their teasing. Jamie doesn't genuinely believe Alex is a cheat but it makes for a funny joke in the moment.

I bet that sounded a lot funnier in your head.

As a witty way to come back, Alex said: **I bet that sounded a lot funnier in your head.**

It's a cheeky way **to acknowledge someone's poor attempt at humour**. It can definitely lighten the mood and get a good laugh, especially when you're in a social setting and the vibes are good. I wouldn't recommend trying this out with people you've just met - it probably won't end well.

You know you love it!

Jamie fired back at Alex by saying, '**You know you love it!**'

It's something you can say after teasing someone, like a nudge saying that **they actually enjoy the teasing and the joke's all in good fun**.

You joking and me pretending it's funny.

Now, Alex comes back with, '**Oh, for sure! It's what holds our friendship together: you joking and me pretending it's funny.**' This is a fantastic example of the playful teasing I've been talking about.

Alex jokingly suggests that their friendship is based on Jamie making jokes that aren't really funny and Alex pretending they are. **This isn't to be taken literally**; it's an affectionate way of acknowledging their dynamic, where teasing and joking are part of how they express their affection for each other.

It highlights a common aspect of close friendships: **the ability to tease each other in a loving way**.

I don't think my ego could take it.

Finally, Jamie continues with Alex's joke by saying, '**Well, keep pretending. I don't think my ego could take it.**' It's another example of self-deprecating humour. Here, Jamie is jokingly suggesting that her ego, or sense of self-esteem, is so fragile that she relies on Alex's pretend laughter.

It's a funny, exaggerated way of saying she values Alex's playful support, even if it's all pretend.



CONVERSATION: PART 2

Now, here is the transcript for the second part of the conversation.

Host: First question! What's the longest river in the UK?

Alex: Oh, too easy!

Jamie: Oh yeah? How about we make this interesting? If you get this wrong, you buy the next two rounds.

Alex: Ha! Deal - piece of cake. It's the River Thames!

Host: The correct answer is... the River Severn.

Jamie: Nice one, genius!

Alex: Oh, alright, Einstein! Let's see how you do with the next one.

Jamie: Please. Stick with me and you might learn a thing or two.

Alex: Oh, I highly doubt that!

Jamie: Me too!





Language Explanation

Oh yeah?

This is Jamie's playful way of doubting Alex's confidence. It's like saying, **'Really? Are you sure about that?'**

Jamie is challenging Alex's assurance, subtly teasing him by questioning his certainty about knowing the answer. **'Oh yeah?'** is a very common expression, often used to express a hint of sarcasm.

Nice one, genius!

After Alex's incorrect answer, Jamie's response is dripping with irony. She's being extremely sarcastic, calling Alex a **'genius'** right after he gets the answer wrong.

The irony here is that Jamie is not actually complimenting him because **what she actually means is the opposite.**

Ironically, calling someone 'a genius' accomplishes the same goal but keeps everything light and playful.

Oh, alright, Einstein!

Here, Alex flips the script, calling Jamie **'Einstein'** sarcastically after being teased about his intelligence. Using Einstein's name - **a symbol of high intellect** - as a sarcastic remark is his way of saying, **'Okay, if you're so clever, let's see you do better.'**

It's a nice back-and-forth that sticks to the same theme of being intelligent.



you might learn a thing or two

Finally, Jamie says, 'Stick with me and **you might learn a thing or two**,' which is her way of **rubbing it in**, as she knows more about British trivia than Alex.

She jokingly says that just by Alex being around her, he will learn many new things because of her vast experience.

I highly doubt that!

When Jamie says he can teach Alex something, and Alex responds with '**I highly doubt that!**', he's playfully saying, '**I don't think I'm going to learn anything from you.**'

This statement is a straightforward denial that he could learn from Jamie, but still in a joking manner. It's more of a playful disbelief in Jamie's expertise or knowledge. It's a continuation of their friendly teasing, keeping their conversation lively.

'**Highly doubt**' is also a strong collocation that you will hear quite often to express disbelief. Here are some examples:

- I **highly doubt** she'll be there.
- We can try your plan but I **highly doubt** it'll work.
- Maybe they didn't see your message but I **highly doubt** it.

Me too!

Jamie ends their back-and-forth by agreeing with Alex's doubt when she says '**me too**', which is a bit self-deprecating. She's saying, '**Yeah, you're probably right; I don't have much to teach.**' This wraps up their playful exchange with a shared laugh, stepping back from the teasing.

It's always good to know when teasing and joking around has gone on long enough. At a certain point, you know it's time to call it quits, and this kind of agreement or going along with the person's joke about you is a great way of saying, '**Alright, enough teasing. It's time to move on.**'



Glossary

1. **back-and-forth** n /ˌbækənˈfɔːθ/ - an exchange of words or actions between people
 - After a long back-and-forth, we finally agreed on a place to meet.
2. **cheeky** adj /ˈtʃiːki/ - behaving in a playful, slightly disrespectful way
 - He gave a cheeky grin after making a joke about the teacher.
3. **ego** n /ˈiːgəʊ/ - a person's sense of self-esteem or self-importance
 - She has a big ego and doesn't like to admit she's wrong.
4. **to err on the side of caution** phrase - to be especially careful rather than taking a risk
 - With the roads so icy, it's better to err on the side of caution and drive slowly.
5. **to fancy** v /ˈfænsi/ - to like or want something, or to want to do something
 - I fancy a slice of cake with my tea.
6. **humorous** adj /ˈhjuːmərəs/ - funny, causing laughter
 - He made a humorous comment during the meeting.
7. **humorously** adv /ˈhjuːmərəsli/ - in a way that is funny and causes laughter
 - She humorously described her first attempt at skiing.
8. **in full force** phrase - with a lot of strength, energy, or in large numbers
 - The entire community was out in full force for the annual parade.
9. **mate** n /meɪt/ - (slang) friend
 - My mates encouraged me to ask you out.

10. **pub quiz** n /pʌb kwɪz/ - a quiz held in a pub, involving teams answering questions on various topics
 - We won the pub quiz last night and got a free round of drinks!
11. **round** n /raʊnd/ - when someone buys drinks for a group, usually taking turns
 - It's your round next – what is everyone drinking?
12. **sarcastic** adj /sɑː'kæstɪk/ - using irony to mock or tease
 - She was being sarcastic when she said she loved doing homework.
13. **self-esteem** n /ˌselfɪ'stiːm/ - confidence in one's own worth or abilities
 - Playing sports can really help build a child's self-esteem.
14. **subjective** adj /səb'dʒektɪv/ - based on personal feelings, tastes or opinions
 - Whether you like the film or not is entirely subjective.
15. **to tease** v /tiːz/ - to make fun of someone playfully
 - He likes to tease his sister about her fear of spiders.
16. **to rub it in** phrase - to make someone feel worse about a mistake or misfortune
 - I know I lost the game, but you don't have to rub it in!
17. **trivia** n /'trɪviə/ - details or pieces of information
 - We played a game of trivia at the party.
18. **Trivia Crack** n /'trɪviə kræk/ - a game application where players answer questions from various categories
 - He's addicted to playing Trivia Crack on his phone.
19. **witty** adj /'wɪti/ - showing quick and inventive verbal humour.
 - Her witty remarks always make the whole room laugh.

Phrases to express discomfort

1. **I know you might be joking but that actually hurt my feelings.**

- This phrase communicates that the impact of the words was hurtful, regardless of the intent.

2. **Can we change the subject? I'm not really comfortable with this topic.**

- This allows you to steer the conversation away from sensitive areas without directly confronting the teaser.

3. **I think that's enough. Let's keep things positive.**

- Useful for drawing a line and setting a boundary that encourages a more positive interaction.

4. **That comment was a bit too much for me. Let's not go there.**

- Directly addresses a specific comment that was offensive, making it clear what the issue was.

5. **I love a good joke but can we tone it down a bit?**

- This is a gentle way of asking for sensitivity while acknowledging that humour was the likely intention.

6. **Let's keep our jokes fun and not at someone's expense, alright?**

- Promotes a group norm of respectful humour.



Activity

Choose the words from the word bank to complete the dialogue.

Liam: Right, well, this kitchen is an absolute mess, isn't it? I can't live like this!

Maya: (1) _____. How on earth did we let it get this bad? And I'm going on holiday today, so I can't stick around to help.

Liam: (2) _____. I was hoping you might have a plan of attack.

Maya: A plan? I (3) _____ we'll get this sorted ourselves unless you've got a magic cleaning fairy hiding somewhere.

Liam: Let's try to (4) _____, okay?

Maya: 'Positive'? You're (5) _____, aren't you? Liam, the sink's overflowing!

Liam: Alright, alright, I deserved that one. But seriously, what are we going to do?

Maya: Come on, mate, you (6) _____ me on. We just have to knuckle down and get scrubbing!

Liam: Easy for you to say. You weren't the one who cooked that monstrous lasagna last night.

Maya: True, but you were the one who promised to wash up afterwards! Look, we'll put on some music, make a game of it and before you know it; the dishes will be sparkling clean.

Liam: Alright, alright. Music and dishwashing games it is.

a. Don't rub it in	b. keep this positive	c. You and me both	d. having a laugh	e. highly doubt	f. must be having
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Answers:

f (1) c (2) e (3) b (4) d (5) a (6) e

